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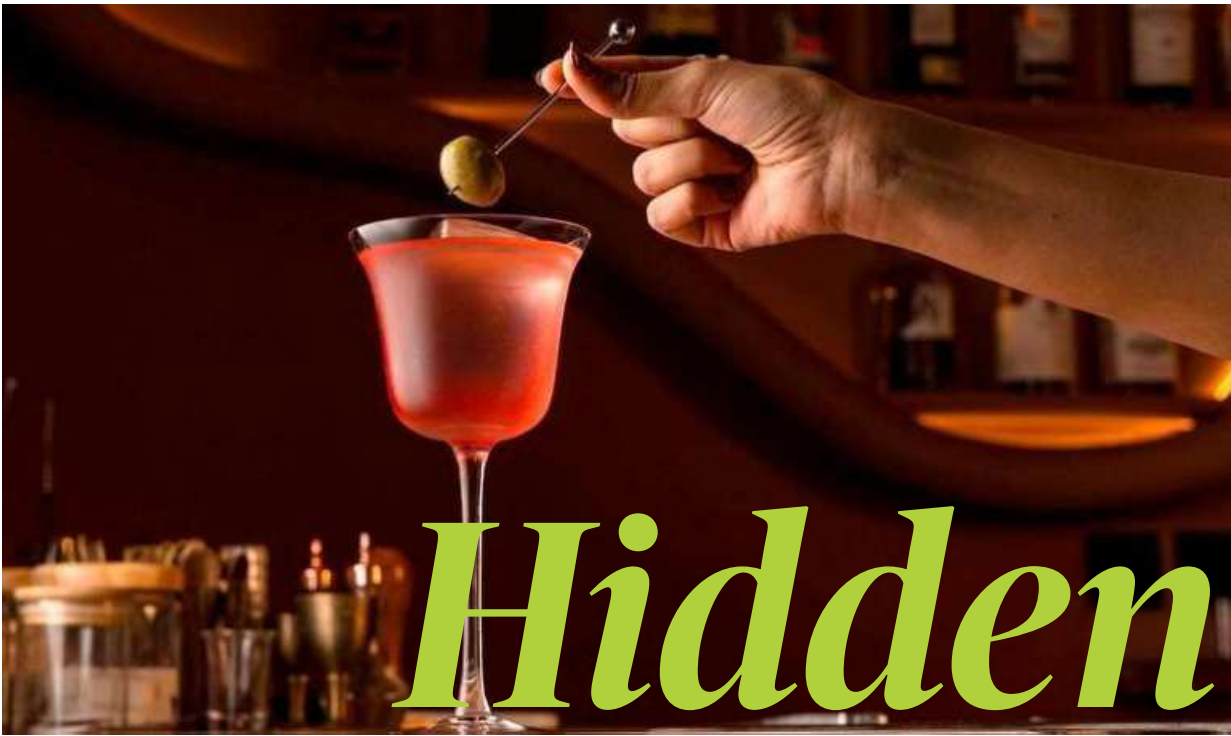
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Barry Rodgers
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For a format born out of evasion, the speakeasy has found a surprisingly stable home in Delhi. Delhi's social life has always operated on layers – of invitation, proximity, and knowledge – and within this framework, the speakeasy feels more like an extension of how the city already moves after dark.

When Rakshay Dhariwal, founder and managing director, Pass Code Hospitality and Maya Pistola Agavepura, opened PCO in Vasant Vihar in 2012 – now widely regarded as India's first speakeasy – its phone booth entrance and interiors nodded to classic speakeasy aesthetics, but the intent was pragmatic rather than nostalgic. "The filter was the driving force," Rakshay says. The passcode, he explains, was not about secrecy, but a subtle barrier that ensured everyone inside had actively chosen to be there.

That idea has slowly become the backbone of Delhi's speakeasy culture. Without signboards or street-facing visibility to pull in foot traffic, these spaces are forced to rely on reputation, memory and word of mouth. Rakshay says, "The drinks programme is the anchor."

The controlled entry of a speakeasy creates what Rakshay describes as a "safe zone", particularly for women.

Hidden in plain sight

As cocktail culture matures, the capital's speakeasies reveal why secrecy still matters

In an era where every good place is instantly tagged, shared and mapped, secrecy has had to evolve. Rakshay is pragmatic about this shift. "True secrecy is a myth," he says. There is a difference between being known and being accessible.

Vikram Achanta, founder and CEO, Tulleeho and co-founder, 30BestBarsIndia and the India Bartender Show, often references William Dalrymple's description of Delhi as a place where multiple histories coexist rather than replace one another, and sees that layering reflected in its bar culture. Over the past year, speakeasies have emerged behind salons, sandwich shops, vinyl stores and tailor shops, particularly in neighbourhoods

like Greater Kailash II, Vasant Vihar and the El Deco Centre. "Delhi is comfortable with discretion and discovery," Vikram says.

That said, he is quick to caution against mistaking format for substance. Indian drinkers today are far more open to variety than they were a decade ago, gravitating towards wine bars, taprooms, spirit-led rooms and tightly defined boutique spaces. In this climate, a speakeasy must justify its secrecy. "If it's secrecy without substance, it won't last," he says.



Raise the bar
Tucked away on a quiet dead-end street at Panchsheel Community Centre, the tailor-shop speakeasy, Noctis, founded by Angad Wasu, is accessed via Instagram and an appointment slip handed to a working tailor – Jagdish Tailor – who finishes his day's labour and begins



(Clockwise from far left) A cocktail at Somewhere Nowhere; bartender at The Bar Behind The Sandwich Shop (TBBTSS); inside Noctis; a cocktail at TBBTSS; a cocktail being made at Somewhere Nowhere. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



ushering guests in at precisely seven in the evening. For Angad, originality lies not in theatrics but in discipline. Noise is kept low, dress codes remain understated, and the music – always jazz – sits firmly in the background. "This isn't a place you come to dance," he says. "It's about conversation."

Inside, the drinks programme does the heavy lifting: house-made vermouths, curated liqueurs, even in-house bottled water. The room is deliberately small, capped at around 30 seats. Scale, Angad believes, erodes precision.

Delhi-based digital brand manager Debarati Roy says speakeasies, by design, feel easier to navigate. She adds that the higher price point does not bother her. "I'm okay paying a little more because it's not just about the drink, it's about the experience."

A similar instinct guides The Bar Behind The Sandwich Shop, located in the Basant Lok neighbourhood. Difficult to Google, with a dormant social media presence and no

publicly listed number, the bar builds discovery into the experience. A modest first-floor sandwich shop gives way to a curtain that leads to a compact room. Co-founder Rishi Mukherjee resists the speakeasy label altogether. There are no passcodes or influencer nights – only word of mouth. "Anyone who finds their way in is welcome," he says, "and the experience itself becomes the currency, passed on through recommendation." As far as security goes, Rishi keeps it simple. "Our staff is trained to anticipate issues, spot early signs of excess, and step in before things escalate."

A similar philosophy underpins The Dressing Room, nestled inside an outpost of the popular Looks Salon, in Vasant Vihar, where access comes via a coded elevator entry shared over Instagram and reservations are mandatory. You are more likely to stumble upon it than search for it deliberately. The focus here is on storytelling, spectacle.

Vansh Pahuja of Somewhere

Nowhere, a Japanese-inspired cocktail bar hidden behind a vinyl store in GK-II, echoes this approach.

The bar's insistence on invisibility was initially unusual, but today, it is in step with Delhi's drinking culture.

Marketing professional Mayanka Uppal is a bit more measured about the speakeasy boom. "A lot of them don't remain speakeasies for long; the secret gets out pretty quickly," she says. "They arrive with a bang, but whether they'll last is another question." What keeps her going back, though, is the menu. "There's a lot of craft involved – different techniques, house blends, even spirits they've infused themselves. That's where people are willing to spend." Cocktails, she notes, usually sit between ₹900 and ₹1,200 and sometimes up to ₹1,500 too, often paired with small plates that do not quite make it a full meal. "Cocktails at speakeasies are priced on a par with regular cocktail bars, but the experience is what justifies the cost, I guess," she says.

She adds: "Clubbing culture has pretty much died. People aren't looking for loud, chaotic spaces anymore; people want places where they can sit, talk, and actually spend time with their group."

In that sense, she sees Delhi settling into a new rhythm. "It's becoming more about smaller, neighbourhood-style bars with their own regulars, almost like little communities. You end up running into the same people."

She adds that some speakeasies are mindful about crowd control. "Places like Noctis limit tables to three or four people. When I visited, we were told no large groups – they want to make sure the volume doesn't get out of hand."

That said, price remains a sticking point. "If they want people coming out regularly, they'll have to bring prices down. Right now, a few cocktails can easily set you back close to ₹10,000 for the night, and that's without food. It's just not sustainable."

Her current favourite? "Pod, tucked inside Savorworks Coffee & Chocolate in GK-2. There's chocolate in the drinks, what's not to like?"

What unites these spaces is not secrecy for secrecy's sake, but restraint. Speakeasies, you could say, endure in Delhi not because they hide, but because their owners understand that the city prefers to reveal itself on its own terms.

Did you know, the Amritsar-based property featured in *Dhurandhar: The Revenge* belongs to the owner of Crown Basmati Rice and took two years and one month to be designed by Jalandhar-based architecture firm 23DC

House that connects Amritsar to Lyari

Amarjot Kaur
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In December 2021, 17-year-old Jalandhar-based architecture firm 23DC landed the opportunity to design one of Punjab's most-talked-about villas – its popularity fuelled by the Ranveer Singh-starrer *Dhurandhar: The Revenge*. While the mansion, Ananda, has captured public imagination through the film's hype, engaging with it architecturally reveals a compelling creative story. Founders Shiv Dada and Mohit Chawla explain the design grammar, functional elements, and aesthetics that define Ananda, and how its spaces bridge the distance between



Amritsar and the on-screen Lyari. Shiv explains: "Any story, especially in cinema, is influenced by the spaces it's set in. Ananda, shown as (Ranveer Singh's character) Hamza's house in the film, is a visual embodiment of his success – a small gangster from Lyari becoming the *shehenshah* of

Karachi." Mohit adds the residence looks almost like a fort, with a huge gate concealing any view of what lies inside; it reflects the security and privacy that the character would want.

"The look of this house doesn't match the typical aesthetic of Lyari, which was intentional, as it shows



(Clockwise from left) The swimming pool at Ananda; the living room; the black basalt and wood façade of the property spanning nearly an acre; the interiors of Ananda; and co-founders of 23DC Mohit Chawla (left) and Shiv Dada (right). SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



how Hamza has risen above the dusty roads of Lyari into the league of high-profile elites," he shares.

Spread across nearly one acre, Ananda's built-up area spans 20,000 square feet and it belongs to the owner of Crown Basmati Rice, an Indian rice brand produced by Amritsar-based DRRK

Foods, says Shiv.

In many ways, Ananda deviates from the traditional, vernacular vocabulary of Punjab's architecture. It neither features the Nanakshahi brick walls, nor the jharokhas (overhanging windows) or jaalis (lattice screens).

The courtyard, however, remains, but that too comes with a modern twist.

So far as Karachi's oldest area Lyari is concerned, the house escapes the working-class neighbourhood's purely functional, minimally ornamented, and concrete-heavy residential buildings. It finds a place of its own, with the choice of black basalt and wood. Shiv says that the intent was to create a private resort-like space that was modern, in accordance with international design register, but carried the quintessential Indian design

essence. It fits the design vocabulary of modern, tropical and minimalistic Indian architecture, he says. The firm took a little over two years to design it.

Shiv adds, "The front façade is decorated through Indian black basalt and wooden louvers, which extend to the interiors. In between the wooden louvers, we installed brass elements to reflect the traditional Indian design aesthetics." Mohit steers the attention towards the screen on the first floor of the façade.

He shares: "Made of wood, it adds to the design but also acts as an architectural element filtering the harsh south-western sunlight. The villa was designed keeping in mind the harsh climate of Punjab. The central courtyard, open to sky, semi-covered pool area sitting – keeps the house naturally cool and ventilated." Mohit says that the house was spotted by the film's team on social media.

"Amritsar was also an advantage for the director as the city's aesthetic loosely gives off the vibe of what modern Pakistan could look like. Hence, their team reached out to us with an idea of shooting the movie there," he confirms, adding that the shoot took about eight-to-10 days.

Though this is the first property by 23DC to have made it to the big screen, the architecture firm has been associated with several projects across India and abroad.

One of their biggest takeaways, as Shiv puts it, is: "People all over Punjab and India are now prioritising Tier-2 cities for their peaceful environment, healthy lifestyle and for staying closer to their roots". And by doing so, they are rewriting Bollywood's perception of Punjab's landscape that goes beyond the pastoral charm of wheat and mustard fields and rural havelis.



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COASTAL FLAVOURS

At Kidilum, Chef Vinu Raveendran lights up Manhattan's dining scene with playful Kerala flavours **P2**

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Geetika Sachdev

 n any given morning, a quick scan of an airport terminal, a neighbourhood café, or even a co-working space reveals something changing in how India dresses. Leggings paired with oversized shirts, sports bras layered under blazers, joggers worn with crisp white sneakers – outfits that once belonged firmly inside gyms now move effortlessly through everyday life.

Ruhani Khanna, a 41-year-old start-up employee in Bengaluru, was once rarely seen outside jeans, tees, or sharply pressed formal shirts. Today, her wardrobe looks markedly different – well-fitted active jackets, tailored joggers, and pieces that carry her through the day without a second thought. “I need clothes that feel relaxed but still look put together,” she says.

A few years ago, such outfits might have been dismissed as overly casual. Now, they sit comfortably within what we call athleisure – clothing that blurs the line between performance and daily wear. The difference today lies in how it is perceived. These are no longer “in-between” outfits; they are the main character.

Performance over style

Globally, the groundwork for this transformation was laid over a decade ago, when brands like Lululemon, Alo Yoga and Nike repositioned performance wear as lifestyle clothing rather than gym-specific gear. What began as niche quickly spilled onto runways, with fashion houses like Miù Miù incorporating elements like windbreakers and technical jackets into seasonal collections.

In India, the shift feels less trend-driven and more rooted in everyday necessity. The pandemic played a decisive role, collapsing boundaries between work, home, and leisure, and forcing wardrobes to adapt in real time. "It accelerated the trajectory of athleisure labels, as hybrid work culture, wellness consciousness, and flexible dressing reshaped wardrobes," says Rachit Soota of Delhi-based RYZ (apparel upwards of ₹1,430), who prefers the term "active fashion" over performance wear.

The numbers reflect this cultural momentum. According to Statista and Technopak, India's athleisure market is projected to grow at a CAGR of 11.2%, reaching over USD \$6.5 billion by 2028, with women driving a significant share of this demand.

But statistics only tell part of the story. The visible change is in everyday life, where clothing that once signalled "off-duty" now reads as intentional. For 32-year-old Mumbai-based marketing professional Aditi Mehra this has translated into a near-uniform. "I wear my workout leggings almost everywhere. They are the only thing that keeps up with how my day moves," she says.

Fitness gear to daily code

This widespread adoption has also fuelled the rise of homegrown labels such as Blissclub, Silvertraq, Cava Athleisure, and Sawsee. Celebrity participation has further expanded the category's visibility. When luxury athleisure label Athletifreak opened its first India store in Delhi in August 2025, actor Shahid Kapoor and entrepreneur Mira Kapoor came on board as strategic partners. Actress Samantha Ruth Prabhu has also entered the space as

A woman with dark hair tied back is standing in a kitchen. She is wearing a light green short-sleeved top and wide-leg trousers of the same color. She is leaning against a white kitchen cabinet with her left hand. The floor is made of brown and white checkered tiles. In the background, there is a white tiled wall, a stainless steel range hood, and a coffee machine on the counter.

Stretching the *dress code*

From leggings at cafés to joggers at work,
here's how India's hybrid work and wellness culture is
driving double-digit growth in the country's
fast-expanding active fashion market

ways to style the same piece, which increases confidence and experimentation," she notes.

India-first labels have also strengthened the segment by designing for local body types and climate conditions: areas that global brands did not always address.

A focus on design

As activewear finds a place in everyday wardrobes, expectations from it have evolved. Comfort alone is no longer enough; it must also look refined.

co-founder of Mile Collective, positioning activewear as an extension of everyday living. “As work, travel, and leisure began to overlap, women increasingly sought clothing that could move seamlessly through the day,” says Minu Margaret, founder, Blissclub (apparel upwards of ₹999). “The change was triggered by a cultural reset around comfort, mobility, and self-expression”

Social media has amplified this transition. Repeated visibility of activewear in everyday settings has normalised it beyond the gym, says Mahi Mohan, founder of Chennai-based Sawsee (apparel upwards of ₹1,799). “More importantly, people now see multiple

A group of four women are posing against a plain white background. They are wearing various styles of leggings and tops. From left to right: the first woman wears a light blue long-sleeved top and white leggings; the second wears a beige tank top and dark brown leggings; the third wears a purple sports bra and matching leggings; the fourth wears a beige short-sleeved top and dark brown leggings. All are wearing white sneakers.

(Clockwise from far left) Outfits from Swasee; Blissclub; Cava Athleisure; Blissclub; Swasee; and Yoga101.

clothing, but to offer versatile pieces like pants, jackets, polos, and crew necks.

More than looks

As athleisure becomes more visible, it inevitably shapes conversations around body image and its association with movement has helped shift focus away from appearance. "Its growing visibility has helped encourage women to prioritise how they feel over how they look," says Minu, adding that inclusive sizing plays a key role in this transition.

At the same time, the category is not without its complexities. Compression, sculpting, and body-contouring designs can sometimes blur the line between support and unrealistic expectations. “The more responsible direction is structural enhancement rather than distortion – support that allows natural movement,” says Rachit.

For Tryambika Shah of Your101 (apparel upwards of ₹1,899), the goal is to avoid reinforcing a

Homegrown brands are responding by designing for entire days rather than isolated workouts. At Blissclub, Minu explains, the process begins by mapping how a woman moves through her routine. Fabric journeys – from raw material to yarn, knit, finish, and dye – are closely monitored to ensure durability and feel.

Colour plays its part too. Neutral-forward palettes allow garments to blend seamlessly into existing wardrobes rather than stand out as gym-specific pieces. "It's a new form of tailoring: sculpted, supportive, and fluid," says Aastha Rattha, founder, Pace Active (apparel upwards of ₹2,800). "You can be comfortable and still look your best; there is no choosing."

Beyond womenswear

While women have driven the category's growth, menswear is catching up albeit with a different design language.

Unlike the more expressive silhouettes seen in womenswear, men's athleisure is about restraint. "The focus here is on perfecting fit, refining fabrics, and delivering strong functionality. Every piece is built to transition effortlessly between training, travel, and everyday routines," says Ria Shetty, co-founder, Cava Athleisure (apparel upwards of ₹1,499).

Blissclub's entry into menswear with its Legendary Collection reflects this thinking. The aim is not to create overtly "active"

singular ideal. "Clothing should encourage people to become the best versions of themselves, not conform to unrealistic standards."

Wardrobe without boundaries

Atheism in India is no longer just functional; it has become symbolic of ambition and self-investment. At the same time, there is a growing sensitivity to climate, body diversity, and value. "That demand is pushing Indian atheism toward a more elevated, design-led future rather than purely trend-driven adoption," says Aastha.

Minu believes the category will continue to merge with mainstream fashion while retaining its performance-led core. "The future is less about strict categories and more about fluid wardrobes," she says. Looking ahead, Mahi foresees labels expanding into casual wear, travel wear, and even softer forms of office dressing, while staying rooted in performance DNA. What began as workout gear is steadily evolving into something far more expansive – a uniform for how contemporary India chooses to move, live, and present itself.



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pick of the week



Who is the liar?

Secrets, scandals, and bad decisions — directed by, Denver Anthony Nicholas, *The Truth* is a witty comedy about Michel, who is having an affair with his best friend's wife. As his lies begin to unravel, he finds himself questioning what is true and who is telling the truth. For wit, twists and delicious chaos. *Playing on April 4, from 3pm to 6pm at the Alliance Française of Madras, Nungambakkam. Tickets on allevents.in*



Make your mark

Shape, press, and sculpt your ideas at The Imprint of Earth, a terracotta relief workshop exploring texture, depth, and form. Guided by artist E Loganathan, participants will create wall-based compositions while learning the nuances of bas-relief techniques. A hands-on, tactile experience that bridges surface and sculpture. *April 4 and 5, at Apparao Galleries, Nungambakkam from 4pm to 6pm. Fee ₹2500 including material. For registrations, call 82209 83016*



Be summer ready

Péro presents Doodles, a Spring Summer 2026 collection inspired by childhood scribbles on walls, paper and floors. With classic checks and mashru stripes the collection introduces weaving techniques like tangalia and handwoven linen gauze with appliqué, patchwork, and crochet. Featuring kurtis, co-ords, dresses, jackets, and T-shirts and more. *Priced ₹26,800. April 7 to 9, from 11am to 7.30pm at the Folly at Amethyst, Royapettah.*



Hunting for eggs

Hop into an egg-citing Easter brunch at Cappella, The Palomar by Crossway. Feast on scotch eggs, mutton dum biryani, chicken Chettinad, kung pao chicken, and vazha poo vada, with classic eggplant parmigiana on the menu. Sweet treats include Easter brownie bites and palada pradhanam alongside games, karaoke, and an egg hunt for all ages. *On April 5, at Cappella, The Palomar by Crossway, from 11.30am to 3.30pm. Starting ₹2199. Reservation call 8925847085*



Shonali Muthalaly
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Kidilum has the audacity to serve idlis on one of the highest rents in the world. This Kerala restaurant, planted in the heart of Manhattan, thumbs its nose at trend-chasing menus and the butter chicken clichés of Lexington Avenue's Curry Hill. Set in the coveted stretch between Flatiron and NoMad, the 74-seater — opened recently — is helmed by Kerala-born Chef Vinu Raveendran. It is the latest project from Hungry Trio, the hospitality group led by Sammeer Raajpal and mother-son duo Archana and Sidharth Sharma, whose portfolio includes Aarzu Indian Bistro, Ramen Nagomi and Esquina No. 525.

I drop by before the official launch and quickly see where that confidence comes from. The team has been handpicked from all over the world, relying on a network built on reputation and friendship. Now, they are having fun. And suddenly, so am I. At the bar, head bartender Harish Subramanian — formerly of The Bombay Canteen and Papa's — greets me with a high-five. In the kitchen, Vinu, who has worked at the two-Michelin-starred Mugaritz in San Sebastián and Carnival by Trësind in Dubai, operates with quick, quiet efficiency, handing us small brass bowls of fluffy podi idlis set in whipped coconut chutney. As Harish shakes up martinis laced with gin, vetiver and curry leaf oil, in proper Mallu tradition, we knock back cold heady glasses of kallu. Their supplier, George



Idlis in Manhattan?

At Kidilum, a new restaurant in Manhattan's Flatiron district, Chef Vinu Raveendran serves podi idlis, prawn pollichadhu and Alleppey fish curry with toddy, making a confident case for hyper-regional Kerala cuisine in New York

Mathew, who has found an innovative way to package toddy with his boutique brand CocoKallu, sits beside me and sighs as he tastes the idli, saying “Now, I miss my mother.” I may be sitting on a barstool in Manhattan, but when I close my eyes, I could be on a veranda in Kerala: the laughter, the easy slide between Malayalam and English, and that almost luminous scent of vetiver. The team hopes Manhattan feels the same way.

Their open kitchen, unusual for an Indian restaurant in New York, flanked by a spice-grinding room, makes it clear that they are unapologetic about the scent of curry that will inevitably perfume the air. “Kerala cuisine has rhythm, heat, aroma, sound. Our kitchen allows guests to experience that intensity first-hand,” says Vinu. He admits that choosing Manhattan was bold. “Especially at these rents! But this is where culture, ambition, and diversity



intersect. If we want Kerala cuisine to stand confidently on the world map, it has to stand where the world is watching.” While Vinu's modern training helps him refine technique and presentation, the soul of Kidilum comes from Kerala. Despite the modern technique and plating, flavours are hauntingly familiar. Tapioca cutlets are served with beetroot reduction, and lamb chops with a black pepper sauce and plum chutney. We lunch on pollichadhu, prawns roasted in

(Clockwise from far left) A spread at Kidilum featuring dishes like paper podi dosas, puttu, Malabari parotta idiyappam, and more; and chef Vinu Raveendran. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



banana leaves and tangy Alleppey fish curry made with barramundi. It is served with a steaming bowl of Kerala red rice, and soft kallu dosas. Though Vinu's favourite meal is a simple rice, fish fry and thoran, his menu draws inspiration from across Kerala: from coastal stir-fried crab meat in dark roasted coconut finished with fennel pollen, to slow braised pork vindaloo, drawing from Kerala's Portuguese influences. “Hyper regional cuisine is not a risk in New York, it's a strength. The city respects authenticity” says Vinu, adding, “We're not trying to simplify Kerala to make it easier. We're inviting people to discover it. And in a city like this, discovery is everything.” Over filter coffee martinis — sweet, dark and bracing — we survey the restaurant all set to welcome its first wave of guests. Vinu is calm as they launch in the most competitive city in the world. He smiles as he explains why: “Sometimes, if a dream is strong enough, you have to be brave with it.”

Kidilum is at 31 W 21st Street, New York, NY 10010, United States. Open from Tuesday-Monday from 5pm to 10pm.



THE NAKED TRUTH

The question of identity

As India tightens its transgender law, in matters of love, trans people are still asked for proof before acceptance

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When Parliament passed the Transgender Persons (Protection of Rights) Amendment Bill, 2026, the debate, at least on paper, was about definitions. Who counts, who qualifies, who can be recognised, and under what conditions. The amendment moves further away from self-identification and towards verification, placing gender within a system that can be assessed and, if necessary, refused. It is presented as administrative clarity. But if you listen closely to the conversations happening outside Parliament, it

sounds like it is something else entirely: a familiar demand to explain yourself before you are allowed to be taken at your word. For many trans people, that demand has never been limited to the State. It has long shaped how they are read, and perhaps how they are loved. Because trans bodies, in India, are rarely allowed to exist without interpretation. A trans woman I spoke to in 2019 described the feeling of being watched on a night out in Delhi — in a way that felt almost investigative. That distinction became painfully clear one evening at a bar. A man had been watching her for most of the night — holding eye contact just long enough to have been read as interest. She hesitated, then decided to walk up to him. “I thought, let me go say hi,



like a normal person would,” she said. What followed was not normal. His expression hardened and he told her — loud enough for his friends to hear — to back off. There was a brief moment when it felt like the situation might escalate. “It was like I had exposed him,” she said. “Like he could look, but I wasn't supposed to respond.” She left soon after, more shaken than she expected to be. “One second I was someone he was interested in, and the next I was something he needed to distance himself from publicly.” That movement from desire to disavowal is something that

comes up often. Another trans woman, who has been in what she describes as a “relationship, but only technically,” for close to two years, spoke about a man who insists on defining their dynamic as casual, even as he behaves in ways that suggest otherwise. He calls, checks in, gets visibly upset when she pulls away, but resists any attempt to make the relationship visible or defined. She laughed when she recounted this, but not because it was funny. “It's only complicated when I ask for clarity,” she said. “Otherwise, everything is very convenient.” What she was describing, without naming it directly, was a kind of containment. A

relationship that is allowed to exist, but only within boundaries that protect the other person from having to account for it. On dating apps like Tinder, Bumble, and Grindr, several trans users described interactions that felt like sorting mechanisms. A trans woman in Mumbai put it this way: “If I say I'm trans upfront, that becomes the entire conversation. If I don't, then I'm ‘hiding’ something. There's no version where I just get to be someone you're talking to.” She described a pattern that has become almost predictable — initial interest, followed by a turn toward questions that come across as interrogation. This isn't incidental. Research emerging from India's queer digital spaces has begun to map patterns that users themselves have long described. A 2021 academic study, *Gay Dating Platforms, Crimes, and Harms in India*, examines how geosocial apps like Grindr can become sites of coercion, extortion, and abuse, particularly because anonymity and stigma make users more vulnerable. This study makes clear that these platforms are not insulated from the biases of the society they exist in. They replicate them, sometimes more efficiently.

For many trans people, the experience of dating is shaped by subtler negotiations. Being desired, but not publicly. Being accepted, but conditionally. Being visible, but only as long as that visibility can be managed. And this is where the law begins to echo the personal. It is framed as governance, as order, as the need for systems that can distinguish between what is valid and what is not. But when applied to identity, it takes shape as scrutiny. And perhaps that is where the real shift lies. Not in definitions or documentation, but in allowing people to exist without turning them into questions that need answering.

A fortnightly guide to love in the age of bare minimum



The perfect Sunday

The idea of an authentic Kerala-style breakfast is not built for restraint. It is generous, layered, and meant to linger. At Kappa Chakka Kandhari, that idea now finds form in a new Sunday breakfast, inspired by the everyday rhythms of homes, tea shops and small eateries across Kerala. Designed as a sit-down, table-served experience rather than a buffet, the meal is both curated and unlimited. It begins with naranga vellam, a simple lime-and-honey refresher, before moving into a starter of chicken cutlets with beetroot sauce. What follows is a sweeping, meat-forward spread: idiyappam with fish thengapala curry, Kerala-style bread with chicken roast, vattayappam paired with duck mappas, pazham pori with beef curry, puttu with kadala curry, and appam served alongside mutton stew and egg roast. The menu stays true to its roots, offering no separate vegetarian selection, save for the traditional kadala curry. “We are launching on Easter, and it will continue every Sunday. This will be available in both Chennai and Bengaluru,” says Chef Ramkumar Varatharaj, head of operations at Kappa Chakka Kandhari. “This is a predominantly non-vegetarian breakfast. There is no separate vegetarian option. The only vegetarian dish is kadala curry, which is part of a traditional combination,” he adds. The breakfast is priced at ₹740 for adults and ₹450 for children between five and 12. Children under five dine complimentary. Serving from 9am to 10.30am. For reservations, call 9858591010

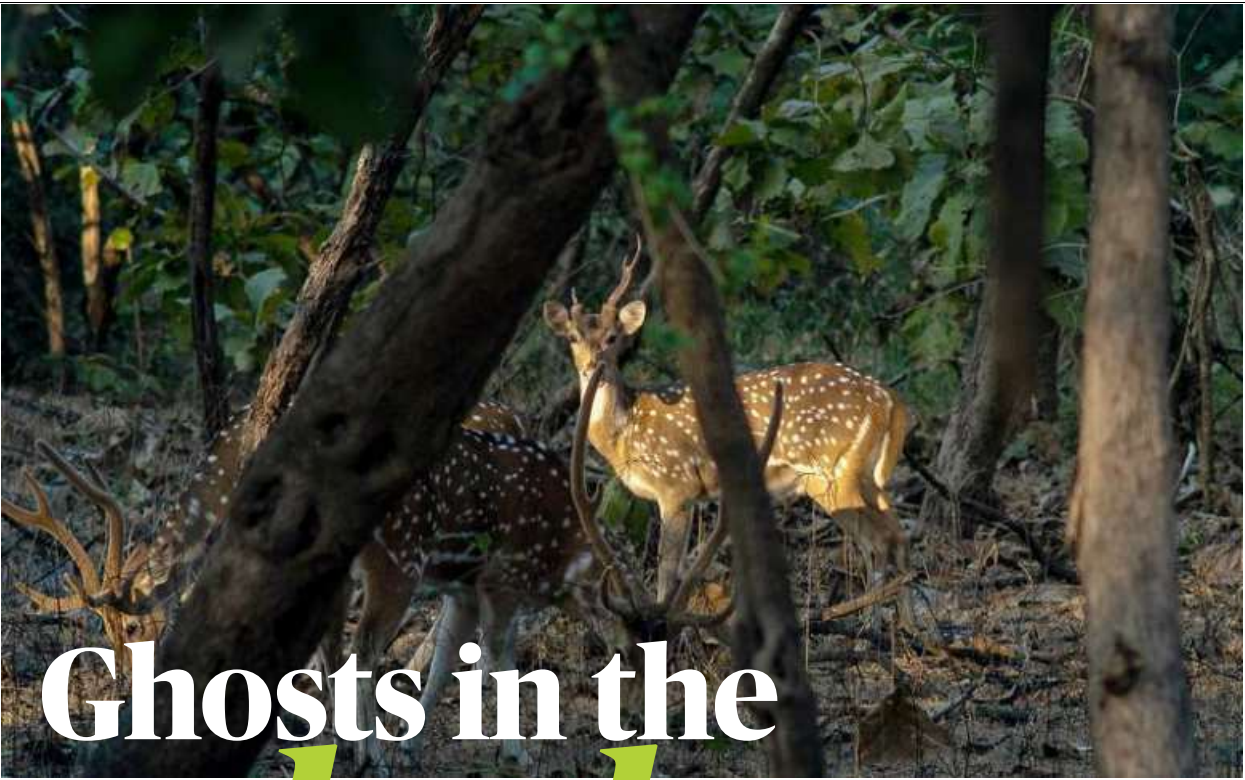
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There is, I'll admit, a faint wariness that creeps up before travelling to Gujarat, which temporarily sharpened the moment my cab drove out of Rajkot Airport to find plainclothes policemen scanning luggage for the faintest whiff of contraband booze that an out-of-stater might have smuggled in to what remains India's most infamously dry state. Still, the prospect of the bounties that lay ahead – of one of the subcontinent's most remarkable biospheres and its regal inhabitants – was enough to dull my reflexive cynicism.

The Sasan Gir, national park stretches across more than 1,400 square kilometres of dry deciduous forest, scrubland, rocky outcrops, and seasonal rivers. This is the only place on Earth where Asiatic lions still roam free – survivors of a near-erasure that once left barely a dozen of their kind clinging to existence in the late 19th Century. Today, more than 600 lions live in and around this forest, alongside leopards, hyenas, crocodiles, sambar, chital, and hundreds of bird species.

Woods at Sasan, where we stayed on the park's edge, sits inside an eight-acre mango orchard just outside the forest boundary. Conceived as the flagship property of 1000 Island Hotels & Resorts by Maulik Bhagat and architect Maria Portella, the retreat spreads across low stone structures positioned carefully between the trees. Thirty-eight private stays sit apart from each other, allowing the orchard to remain intact. Built largely with local stone, lime plaster, reclaimed wood, khadi, terracotta, and cane, the structures rely on thick walls, intelligent orientation, and natural light. Concrete is used sparingly, plastic has been reduced almost entirely, and not a single mango tree was cut to make way for construction.

Laurent Guiraud, the French restaurateur who now oversees operations at Woods, described the retreat's biophilic philosophy through three pillars: culture, community and well-being. Much of the staff come from nearby villages, and dozens of local artisans worked



Ghosts in the darkness

Between pre-dawn jeep rides, and long silences in the brush, Gir, India's last refuge of Asiatic lions, reveals why its resident monarchs still rule its deciduous kingdom

on the construction. "We want to bring more than we take into the ecosystem," he says. Well-being at Woods, he explains, forms a connective tissue that emphasises sleep, silence, darkness, the preservation of ancient natural rhythms and respect for the nocturnal lives that begin where the orchard ends.

Those rhythms made themselves felt on my very first night. I found myself standing beneath the clearest night sky I had seen in years, the orchard opening up above us as constellations sharpened into view one after another. Beneath that sky, the culinary team at Woods prepared a barbecue in the orchard, smoke curling into the cold air while Laurent serenaded us with stories from his early years in India.

Our mornings at Woods began before dawn. On our first day, Akash Ahir – the property's naturalist and an endlessly enthusiastic interpreter of Gir's ecology – led us on a hike through the forest that wrapped



around the orchard. The land here is often frequented by lions in the early hours, a fact Akash mentioned with cheerful nonchalance as we stepped over fresh pug marks pressed into the dust. Eventually, the trail opened into a clearing atop a low rise, where breakfast appeared, and we sat watching the sun lift over a mosaic of forest tracts dissolving into agricultural plots at the horizon. The afternoon drifted past with a Gujarati thali at Swadesh, frequent stops at SOM, the retreat's charming wellness centre, and long

conversations and food before sleep. On safari day, we were up again before dawn, climbing into an open jeep headed for the Gir National Park Centre. Dozens of tourists gathered in jittery clusters, with guides barking instructions. A giant bronze lion presided over the plaza as State-authorised jeeps rolled out one by one. Everyone I had spoken to before this trip seemed suspiciously confident about sightings. Several of them claimed that the probability of spotting a lion here bordered on inevitability, and that I would have to

(Clockwise from left) Spotted deer at Gir; Hilltop breakfast after a morning hike; three lions rest at dusk; a pride of lions quenches its thirst; views from the property at Woods at Sasan. AYAAN PAUL CHOWDHURY, AKASH AHIR, AND SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



possess spectacularly rotten luck to leave the forest without seeing one. The forest at that hour felt immense and inscrutable. Our headlights cut a narrow corridor through the darkness while the canopy thickened overhead and the dry leaves beneath the tires cracked loudly enough to make me wince, as if we were announcing our presence to every creature within a kilometre. My thoughts drifted, somewhat unhappily, toward the 1996 thriller *The Ghost and the Darkness*, where Val Kilmer and Michael Douglas spend two hours being terrorised by a pair of legendary man-eating lions in colonial East Africa. Naturally, as the jeep rattled along the track I began to notice every faint rustle in the brush and every pair of reflective eyes flashing momentarily from the darkness before vanishing again. Barely 20 minutes into the drive, our driver braked. Ahead of us, stretched languidly across the path

as if the road belonged to them, lay three lions. One was a semi-adult male, his mane still developing into a modest ruff, and beside him lounged two adult females whose bodies carried the heavy, satisfied slackness of having clearly eaten their fill. The three of them blinked slowly in the weak glow of our headlights, offering us mild acknowledgment, before returning to the very urgent business of their early morning siesta.

As dawn seeped into the forest, the landscape revealed itself in layers. Spotted deer appeared first, their white markings faintly aglow as they froze mid-step to watch us pass. The terrain kept shifting. Dry deciduous stretches opened into grasslands where the horizon briefly widened, then folded back into thorny acacia and rocky outcrops.

Roughly an hour later, we approached a clearing where a shallow watering hole lay nestled between thick bushes and scattered trees. Around 10 jeeps had already positioned themselves in a semicircle. One by one they gave up and left until we were the only one remaining. "Safari is a waiting game," Akash said calmly. "The people who wait the longest usually win."

Eight lions assembled around the edge of the water – six teenage cubs and two adult females standing watch behind them – as they began lapping the surface in slow, rhythmic motions. The pride, Akash says, descended from two once-dominant male lions named Jai and Veeru. The two had ruled their territory together for years before being killed by rival lions, leaving their cubs vulnerable to being purged of their heredity. What saved them was the tactical intelligence of the adult females, who shepherded the cubs in a cautious migration designed to keep them beyond the reach of the new alphas.

The cubs now jostled each other playfully, biting at tails and nudging shoulders while the adults kept a vigilant eye on the surrounding forest. Not once did they acknowledge the jeep full of stunned humans sitting barely 10 ten metres away. After several long minutes they finished drinking, stretched lazily, and one by one slipped back into the bush from which they had emerged.

This writer was in Gir at the invite of Woods at Sasan



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A crocodile hatchling is crawling on my shirt making its way to my head. I scream. Seven-year-old Ali Mustafa nimbly picks up the reptile. He grins, rather mischievously. We are inside a colourful Nubian village in interior Egypt, located on the West bank of the Nile. To get here, we have to come to Aswan, a city much calmer than the bustling Egyptian capital

Meet the croc stars

A first-person account of Egypt's Nubian culture, where ancient beliefs and crocodiles coexist along the Nile

Cairo. Aswan is a place where you can immerse in history and heritage, much like the rest of Egypt. Apart from exploring popular tourist spots like the Unfinished

Obelisk and the Aswan High Dam, the Nubian village is a must-visit, because of its unique cultural heritage. You are greeted by a herd of camels gently strolling the



A young boy with a pet crocodile at an Egyptian Nubian village. SRINIVASA RAMANUJAM

streets, even as you disembark from a leisurely boat ride that lets you take in the sights and sounds of the Nile. There is also a line of shops selling Egyptian souvenirs, a common sight in most tourist places. But none of this prepares you for this village's fascination for crocodiles: in fact, most houses have atleast one crocodile, with children even playing with them! Ali Mustafa should know. I watch him pick up the hatchling from its habitat, a fish tank perched upon a table in the middle of their home, and tying its mouth carefully. "Do not touch his stomach... he doesn't really like that," Ali tells me, as he coaxes me into holding the crocodile. A few yards away, inside a well, the mother – a crocodile much bigger in size – is watching us.

Reptile god Ancient Egyptians feared crocodiles, one of the top predators in the Nile, endangering both human lives and livestock. Over time, this fear became awe, so much so that they started worshipping the reptile as Sobek, the ancient Egyptian god depicted as a crocodile. Egypt, in fact, has a dedicated temple for the crocodile (Kom Ombo) and a museum that displays mummified crocodiles and

several ancient carvings related to the reptile. While these are remnants of the past, modern Egypt still pays a hat tip to the crocodile through cultural practices, which are seen even today at places like the Nubian village. Some houses preserve crocodile parts. Others display photos of the reptile on the walls. The reptile is still significant to both tourism and the local belief system, according to Hany Rafail, a tour guide who hails from Aswan. "The locals believe that it wards off the evil eye," he explains. "They feel that it absorbs jealousy and ensures prosperity for the family and the village." L Nhmnda seconds that thought. Their family has been living here for generations, and today, along with her husband and three children, these Nubians make ends meet thanks to fishing and tourism. "We have three crocodiles in this house; a mother and her two babies," she informs, even as she offers us some bread and pickled cheese, "Our ancestors worshipped the crocodile. And, we believe that it is still lucky for us."

The writer was in Egypt at the invitation of Egyptian Tourism Authority



Petals and pours

Chennai's InKo Centre is abuzz with two new launches — a flower cafe and a Korean beauty and crafts centre

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A matcha cake in a glass house, surrounded by flowers. This is how I like to spend my teatime these days (if my boss is not watching). I am at InKo Centre's Flower Brew — a delightful combination of a flower shop (Flower Power) and a cafe (Bara and Bean). So, when you enter, the aroma of coffee and the scent of a myriad flowers greet you.

"Korea has this flower cafe culture; they have small, cute spaces where they have books, flowers and cafes. You can pick up a book, grab a bite, look at flowers and just spend as much time as you want. That is where this idea came from," explains Rathi Jafer, director, InKo Centre (The Indo-Korean Cultural and Information Centre). InKo already had this space and Rathi was keen to turn it into "something that extends and connects through our senses". "A hangout where people could connect with everything we have to offer," she adds.

The 15-seater cafe — with indoor and outdoor seating — is run by Chef Cheruba Nelson, who is also associated with Ciacco on Anna Salai, and does a show on Sun TV



titled *Top Cooku Dupe Cooku*. The cafe does Korean-inspired food and bakes. "For example, we have chiffon cake. Is it authentic? No, but because Koreans really enjoy their fruits, we add lots of seasonal fruits and cream — thereby adding a Korean touch," says Cheruba. The menu also features gochujang chicken quiche, Hokkaido toast, kimchi and egg toast, Hokkaido milk gelato with a honey comb on top, green tea, corn tea, Americano, piccolo... the most popular however is the iced matcha made with

(Clockwise from bottom) Bojagi style of wrapping; A Korean fan; external and internal shots of Flower Brew; and a refreshing matcha latte. JOHAN SATHYADAS

oatmilk. "We've noticed in Korea, they really like flavoured milk, so we have banana milk, melon milk, strawberry milk and citron passion fruit-ade and strawberry-ade with a scoop of sorbet," says Cheruba, adding that they open as early at 8am and are exploring healthier options for breakfast.

The flower shop occupies one side of the room; one gets the feel of sitting in a garden. There are roses, orchids, tulips, sunflowers, and flowers I've never seen before. But Jayanthi Ravichandran, who started Flower Power, is there to acquaint you with the blooms. Jayanthi had a flower business in London and started this brand there, decades ago. In 2017, she decided to bring her flower shop to Chennai and set up in Besant Nagar and Akkarai.

While flowers are imported from Holland, South Africa, etc., Jayanthi also sources from local horticulturists in Udhagamandalam, Bengaluru, parts of Kerala, Bengal and Assam. Preethi, who is part of Flower Power is an encyclopaedia of all things flower and foliage related, and takes me through the vibrant display. She pulls out a lilac rose, and says, "This is called Ocean Song; and this pinkish orange rose with a peach undertone is named Kahala, oh, and this white with a tinge of cream is Vendela," she explains animatedly. There are also toffee coloured roses and a variety named Cherry Brandy where the leaves are dual-toned — orange outside and yellow on the inside. "Koreans love roses," says Preethi. Here, they also make Korean style bouquets. In Korean



floristry there is an emphasis on negative spaces, they also follow a monochromatic style where different shades of one colour are put together, and they use lot of natural twigs and barks, she says. Even the packaging is different. "At Flower Brew, the plan is to host workshops on flowers for home, playing with floral arrangements, Korean style arrangements, and also floristry as a career," says Jayanthi.

Rathi then leads us to Pure Han, a new spot within the premises, that is dedicated to Korean skincare (with

brands like Nuskini, Beauty of Joseon, Innisfree, and Serenu and also offers skincare consultancy and a 30-minute skin ritual that uses K-products and galvanic devices), crafts, gifts and souvenirs (like bookmarks, wine stoppers), and traditional wrapping styles like boujagi that uses silk cloth. "The Korean community in Auroville does this. We've got some of them to come as tutors and teach these skills at workshops," says Rathi.

As I leave, Preethi resurfaces, to show me the Signature plant (*Clusia*

rosea) from Indonesia that has now made InKo Centre its home. "There's a belief that you can write your wish on one of the leaves and it could come true. Or you could just write a message on these succulent leaves. And when you come back here later, it'll still be there," she smiles.

InKo Centre is located at 18, Adyar Club Gate Road, Raja Annamalaipuram. For details, call: 044 24361224



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Colour therapy

Apparao Galleries is hosting a workshop titled The Cultivated Palette, on April 4 from 3pm to 6pm at Shridharani Gallery, Triveni Kala Sangam, New Delhi. Conducted by artist Rajarshi Sengupta, the workshop will teach participants to create natural pigments from plant-based materials and apply them on paper, cloth, canvas, and wood. Designed to explore the relationship between material, process, and surface, the session aims to offer an understanding of colour derived from natural sources. For Registration, call 8220983016; fee starts at ₹2,500.

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Malayalam

Old-fashioned political thriller



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One of the obvious shortcuts to write an engaging political drama is to draw inspiration in ample measure from real-life events. Amid a hectic election season, director B Unnikrishnan brings back the essence of that era in *Prathichaya*, woven around political events that rocked Kerala over a decade ago.

With this story as the foundation, the filmmaker, who has also written the screenplay, fills the gaps with family drama and tales of corporate thuggery, both of which have political implications. The film imagines a political arena where everything depends on the image of the leaders, manufactured or otherwise, and much less on their policies or ideologies. So, the visual media also appears as a key player in the drama, as one of the purveyors of lies that destroy lives.

Careful mythmaking goes into creating the character of Chief Minister Varghese (Balachandra Menon), whose life incidents remind us of a real-life politician. He is not the squeaky, clean, and idealistic politician usually seen in such films. Rather, he has his share of grey areas and corrupt practices, notwithstanding which, he is portrayed as a righteous human who has equal amounts of pragmatism and cunning. A political scandal erupts, putting his reputation on the line, when his son John Varghese (Nivin Pauly), a technocrat who has been reluctant to join politics, enters the scene with a vow to restore the leader's lost image.

Although marginally better than some of Unnikrishnan's recent outings, *Prathichaya* is also saddled by the ills that have marred his films, be it the heady-handed drama or the needless exposition in several scenes. The operations of the corporate entity that seeks to control governance by targeting powerful politicians and John's "clever" ways to build his image and respond to his adversaries have an air of familiarity and predictability about them. It does not shock or surprise you. The resolution of the issues seems far too easy and convenient. Some of the fictionalised elements injected into the real story are unintentionally funny, especially the CM's son's ideological and familial links to the opposition party.

The only saving grace is perhaps Balachandra Menon's controlled performance as the CM, delivering the dramatic lines with practised elegance. Nivin Pauly is evidently not in his comfort zone, as he is unable to bring the necessary gravitas to the role of a powerful political player. The characters are written without any element of surprise, most notably in the case of the corporate honcho played by Sharafudheen, who is clearly on the side of evil from the start.

Even with a bucket of whitewash, this old-fashioned political thriller cannot get a contemporary facelift.

Prathichaya is currently running in theatres



Vijay Sethupathi lives many lives

Manikandan makes an impressive series debut with *Kaattaan*, which takes viewers on a thrilling, slow-burn journey through the fragmented life of a mysterious dead man

Tamil

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In his 2011 Man Booker Prize-winning novel 'The Sense of an Ending', Julian Barnes writes about the role of corroboration in how we remember a life. He writes that what youngsters fail to envision about old age is that discovering, "for example, that as witnesses to your life diminish, there is less corroboration, and therefore less certainty as to what you are or have been." It's hard not to think of this perception of life while watching M Manikandan's new series, *Muthu Engira Kaattaan*, a 10-episode saga that takes us through many corroborations of a truly spectacular life one dead man had led.

We begin a week before a police station shuts down, owing to a prolonged lack of cases. A cop, displeased by the news, finds at a desolate foothill something that would forever change his life and the fate of his unit: the severed head of a mysterious man who seems to have died with a frightful grin. An investigation into the head (this is how we are introduced to actor Vijay Sethupathi) takes the cops on a fascinating journey in this thrilling rumination on one man and his multiple identities.

The characters at the Periyaveerampatti police station are distinct with their own quirks. M Kaalai Pandiyan (Vadivel Murugan) is a part-time cop and a full-time goat rearer, or that is how his boss, Sub Inspector Sidharthan (Muthukumar), puts it. For Kaalai, the news of the station shutting down means he would soon have to choose between shepherding and being a cop, and being a cop would then mean moving out of his hometown. Sidharthan then becomes a stark departure from the routine, brutish Tamil cinema cops; here, the cops treat fellow human beings with utmost respect and trust. The third cop who joins the investigation, Thangamudi (Singam Puli), however, is eager to work at a real police station that's bustling with activity, though he is clearly the laziest of the lot.

Kaattaan

Creator: M Manikandan

Cast: Vijay Sethupathi, Vadivel Murugan, Muthukumar, Risha Jacobs, Milind Soman

Storyline: A severed head sparks an investigation that pieces together the many lives of an elusive man through conflicting accounts.



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Sidharthan, with the help of a localite (Balaji Sakthivel), figures out that the severed head belongs to Muthu, a man who once worked as a bodyguard with a travelling dance troupe. Meanwhile, Kaalai and his wife dine at a local hotel, whose owner surprisingly narrates the story of how Muthu paid huge sums to buy the parotta stall from his former, cruel boss and made him the owner of the stall. More accounts of Muthu emerge as the cops follow the trails. Muthu was once a watch mechanic hired by a North Indian man from Mumbai; he was also an elephant mahout in Kerala who became a local MLA's trusted henchman; he was also a strange tempo driver who bought goat droppings from villagers with money; and many more. A key detail that emerges through all these accounts is that Muthu was also a wealthy man who carelessly spent his money.

On one end, he seems to have taken great pleasure in the quietness of life, but on the other, he never hesitated to show you why he's called 'Kaattaan', meaning a wild ruffian. He has no family to care for, but shows much loyalty to a do-gooder businessman, Sivettan (Milind Soman), whose orphanage Muthu managed for a few years.

He was a peripatetic kindred soul who wandered along with no anchor to his life, and yet, when love knocked on his door for a second time, Muthu accepted it with open arms, hoping to live for a few fleeting moments the dreamy life of those who could afford to grow roots.

A man is a sum of all his actions, thoughts, and contradictions, and the most fascinating aspect of *Kaattaan* is how it captures the pluralities of man through these accounts. It's a fascinating portrait of a man who lived the life of ten men. Therefore, it is something to witness how one picture of a headless corpse becomes a picture of a deity at a hotel, a symbol of vengeance, a closure to those awaiting his return, and a reminder of all those who come from somewhere, cross our paths, only to take us somewhere else.

In the final episodes, when the many arcs of Muthu converge, it makes for a violent action extravaganza that you don't expect from Manikandan. Who thought

that even he would pick up the Mocobot? In his television debut, the director shows a distinct knack for creating an atmosphere where Muthu's many extremes could thrive. The tone and tempo of the series feel appropriate for the longer format. Manikandan (writing alongside B Ajithkumar and La Rajkumar) also avoids cliches, like ending the episodes with contrived cliffhangers, and lets the intrigue of Muthu's identity and the whodunit keep us hooked.

Silences punctuate these slow-burning episodes, while calls of peacocks and sounds of everyday village life remind us that this is a Manikandan product. Characters are filled with enough material to make them seem lived-in, be it the montages of Madurai Meena (Risha Jacobs), a dancer who falls in love with Muthu, or a passing shot of Muthu bidding adieu to his tuskier friend Ganesh.

This, of course, isn't to say that *Kaattaan* is perfect. At first, Kaalai's family life (VJ Paaru appears as his wife Lalitha) is shown to help us understand the pressure that's going on Kaalai's mind – he moves the decapitated head to ensure it comes within the station's jurisdiction, a decision he takes to delay the shutting down of the police station. The sub plot ends with Kaalai handing over a pregnant goat to his househelp, but we wonder if scenes set at Kaalai's house had overstayed their welcome to become unnecessary fillers.

But then, without these scenes, *Kaattaan* would also miss making a subtler point – the final corroboration of who Muthu is. To Kaalai, Sidharthan and Thangamudi, Muthu is an enigma, a dead man who offered them a once-in-a-lifetime opportunity: to tell his story to the world, and in the process, find something resembling purpose for their lives as policemen. Now it is upon you to find out what Muthu's life means to you. If Julian Barnes spoke of the lack of corroborations to ascertain the meaning of a life, Manikandan writes one too many witnesses of a life to show that the full picture will always remain elusive. You are many and one, all at the same time.

Muthu Engira Kaattaan is currently streaming on JioHotstar

George Maryan cannot save this tiresome, insincere comedy romp

Tamil

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Actor GV Prakash Kumar's latest comedy romp, *Happy Raj*, does somersaults through its many attempts at humour, all hinging on actor George Maryan's physique, and hopes that its two-faced redemption in the climax would make us forgive its missteps.

It is the oldest trick in the book. And yes, there have been countless Tamil films that pose a certain orientation before flipping it in the end for a 'message'. They had many redeeming qualities, like good humour and organically set-up characters and conflict. However, one cannot expect anything honest in the clumsily conceived *Happy Raj*.

The chief issue with the film is that everything leading up to the 'message' seems crass and exploitative. For over an hour, the Maria Raja Elanchezian-directed film



tries to get you to empathise with the plight of its titular protagonist – all the problems in Anand Raj a.k.a Happy's life lead to his father Kathamuthu (George), whose short gait and appearance are a subject of ridicule among the townsmen. Happy grows up with a lot of shame due to this, and you do understand why he feels this way – it would certainly affect one if you are constantly bullied due to your school teacher-father's nickname 'Kuthiraimuttai,'

meaning horse's egg. Now, *Happy Raj* would have been a different film had it actually cared about the wretchedness of this situation – it instead uses it for cheap gags or to generate sympathy for Happy. When it is not about George, the film uses Happy's cracked mirror for momentary pleasures – like how Kavya (Sri Gouri Priya), Happy's colleague who becomes his girlfriend, feigns a reaction when a hesitant Happy sends her his family

portrait for her approval. *Happy Raj* becomes repulsive and regressive very soon, from a scene in which Happy's ill-advised father brings a whole town to attend the wedding anniversary celebrations of his prospective in-law, Kavya's business tycoon father Rajiv and her mother Reena. For Kathamuthu, this was akin to the traditional bride-seeing ceremony, so he came with his clan, donning traditional attire and carrying offerings. However, their presence and "unsophisticated" behaviour humiliate the "more classy" Rajiv. Again, Happy and Kathamuthu make a case against this classism later, but until then, the film exploits this trope for cheap gags.

That this whole sequence is meant to be the crucial turning point for Happy and Kavya adds undue pressure to make it as funny as possible. But even jokes that aren't about George Maryan's looks, background or the consequent situation do not induce laughter. The presence of Madurai Muthu and Adhirchi Arun as Happy's friends, too, does nothing to save the film. A

bit about two North Indian, paan-chewing train seat-occupiers who later keep appearing at different social gatherings Happy finds himself in, gets annoying after recurring a few times.

Let's now address the tonal change towards the end – you see this 'message-y' climax coming from miles away. And yes, if taken without context, this might seem like an honest, progressive point. In an industry with a sketchy history of

body-shaming, it's commendable for a mainstream film to take a stand against it, to argue that it's what's within that reflects a person's real beauty. However, director Maria demands a lot to forget all the coercion we must endure to get to that point. For instance, at one point, Kathamuthu points out how even his own son, Happy, is biased and sees him as more malleable than the sophisticated Rajiv. If anything, this only paints clearly the hypocrisy in the film's stance: even the film seems to believe that George Maryan is more suited for such humour than Abbas.

Be it a scene between Kathamuthu and Rajiv on a riverbank, or one that features the central father and son, there's a lot of heart in the climactic portions that make you wish a better draft – one that took its endeavour more honestly – with some wittier jokes. It would have then truly been a Happy Raj.

Happy Raj is currently running in theatres

They Will Kill You

Director: Kirill Sokolov

Starring: Zazie Beetz, Myha'la, Paterson Joseph, Tom Felton, Heather Graham, Patricia Arquette

Storyline: A woman wanting to rescue her sister gets more than she bargained for



A gory giggle fest

English

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Why are swanky apartments in New York the scene of evil, bloodthirsty cultists? There was Roman Polanski's uber creepy *Rosemary's Baby* (1968), based on Ira Levin's eponymous 1967 novel.

The movie, now streaming on Netflix (watch it before the dreaded suitcase appears), tells the story of an actor making a deal with the devil.

Polanski famously flew celebrated hairstylist Vidal

Sassoon from London at the cost of \$5,000 to cut the lead actor, Mia Farrow's hair, in what proved to be a canny publicity stunt, though in all fairness, Rosemary does get a haircut by Sassoon in the book as well.

Even the sweet and hilarious *Only Murders in the Building* features a bunch of murders happening in a posh apartment building on Manhattan's Upper West Side. It must be the insane rents and the lovely old buildings in New York that give rise to all sorts of speculation – something like if you were to get a lovely apartment in Whitefield or HSR Layout for an incredibly low rent, you could be sure of some sort of hanky-panky behind the soaring concrete and glass façades.

And so it is that we are in another New York apartment building, the Virgil, of the same vintage; more than a 100 years old, whispering of wealth, privilege, and of course Satanism. Asia (Zazie Beetz) comes to The Virgil looking for her sister, Maria

(Myha'la), who was last heard of working there.

Asia has been in prison for the last 10 years for attacking their abusive father, and feels guilty for abandoning Maria. Although the man (Angus Sampson) helping her find Maria warns Asia against The Virgil, Asia heads for the apartment building in the pouring rain.

She is met by the superintendent, Lilith (Patricia Arquette), who shows Asia her room and introduces her to some of the wealthy residents, including Kevin (Tom Felton) and Sharon (Heather Graham).

Asia goes to bed in a seemingly comfortable room only to be woken up at 3.18 am (which, as we all know, is devil time) to hooded figures out to get her. Then follows a crazed chase through the building where Asia manages to stay just half a step ahead of her tormentors, who refuse to stay dead, and learns the dreadful truth about The Virgil, literally from a pig's head on a stake

(*Lord of the Flies*, anyone?).

The movie is beautifully shot, and Kirill Sokolov has created the different circles of hell reminiscent of Dante's *Inferno*. The roving eye is a fun detail, and while evocative of *Kill Bill* and *6 Underground* is its own gloopy creature. Keeping the action contained within a building for 90 minutes is no mean feat, and Sokolov manages it with flair.

There are lovely soaring, swooping shots of lifts and corridors. The sequence of Asia going up a crawl space is excellent and creates a gaming look and feel. The movie might have got repetitive with the killings and decapitations, if it were not for the tight plotting, generous dollops of humour, and Beetz's wholehearted commitment to the role. Short, fast, and furious, *They Will Kill You* is a different, gory, but equally enjoyable summer film.

They Will Kill You is currently running in theatres

Snippets



Sanjay Dutt to star in Aakhri Sawal; first look, release date out

Actor Sanjay Dutt unveiled the first look poster of his upcoming film, *Aakhri Sawal* which will be released in theatres on May 15.

The first look poster features Sanjay donning an intense look as he is surrounded by a big question mark. Sharing the poster, he wrote in caption, "The question India never stopped asking. Get ready to know the answer on 15th May only in cinemas."

The film is based on the 100-year journey of Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS), a right-wing organisation founded in 1925 by Keshav Baliram Hedgewar. It is directed by Abhijeet Mohan Warang, known for helming the 2021 National Award winning film, *Picasso*.



Sydney Sweeney's thriller sequel film gets a release date

Sydney Sweeney's *Housemaid's Secret* is all set to arrive in theatres on December 17, 2027. Directed by Paul Feig, the film is a sequel to the hit thriller *The Housemaid*.

The Housemaid became a commercial hit with nearly USD 400 million globally against a USD 35 million budget.

Lionsgate, the studio behind the twisted R-rated suspense thriller, is again positioning the film as counter-programming during the busy Christmas corridor.

The *Housemaid's Secret* is currently scheduled to debut on the same day as *Avengers: Secret Wars* and *Lord of the Rings: The Hunt for Gollum*, which hail from male-skewing franchises.

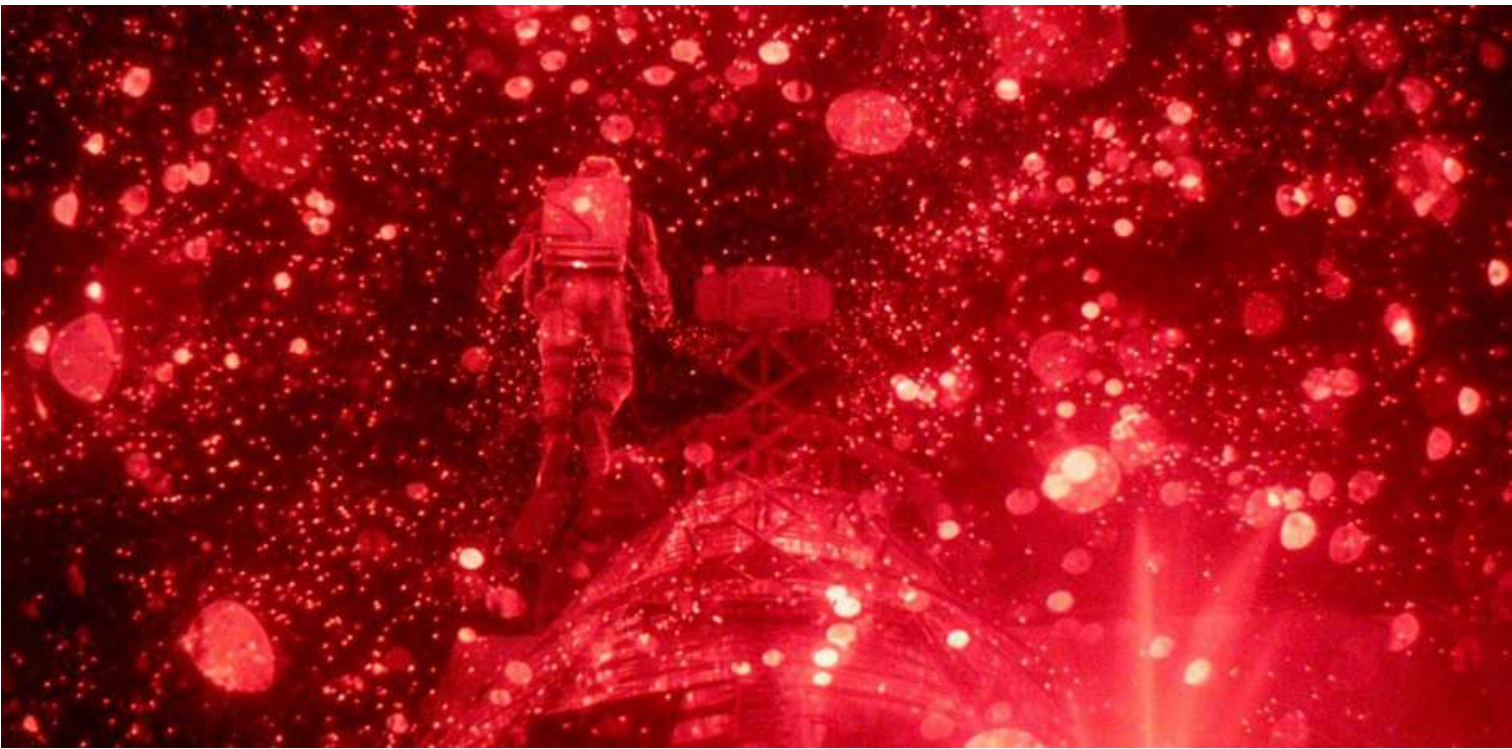


Vijay Varma's Prime Video series Matka King gets a release date

Streaming giant Prime Video has announced that its upcoming original drama series, *Matka King*, headlined by Vijay Varma, will premiere on the platform on April 17. The news was announced on March 29, with a teaser video that offers a glimpse into the world of the series.

Set in the fast-changing Bombay of the 1960s, the series traces the fictional journey of an enterprising cotton trader who creates a new gambling system, dubbed 'Matka', turning an elite pastime into a nationwide phenomenon.

It features Kritika Kamra, Sai Tamhankar, Siddharth Jadhav, Bhupendra Jadawat, and Gulshan Grover in lead roles.



A charming doomsday bromance

Ryan Gosling breeds extinction-level microbes, and liveblogs his own terrible decisions in Phil Lord & Christopher Miller's cosy, summer sci-fi

English

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Phil Lord and Christopher Miller have made another bright, buoyant, summer blockbuster that relishes in its nerdy delights and reminds us why going to the movies will always slap (IMAX or otherwise).

Adapted from Andy Weir's 2021 novel, with Drew Goddard once again stepping in after *The Martian* to translate dense scientific prose into something legible and propulsive, *Project Hail Mary* opens with Ryan Gosling's Dr. Ryland Grace waking up aboard an interstellar spacecraft, disoriented, half-lucid, and very much alone, his memory wiped clean by prolonged hypersleep as the story begins to fold in on itself through a steady drip of flashbacks that reconstruct his identity and the stakes of this Hail Mary effort.

The science here retains Weir's signature density. The microscopic threat to humanity is dubbed the astrophage or "star-eater", that pushes Earth towards an inevitable extinction-level event while also offering an improbable solution in the form of a volatile fuel source; the film does a commendable job of staging these abstract scientific ideas through tactile experimentation, even as it occasionally oversimplifies or dumbs down its logic for comic relief.

Gosling understands this calibration instinctively, shaping Grace as a man devoid of any semblance of heroic resolve, defined instead by a series of small, often reluctant choices that accumulate into something resembling courage. He plays the character's clumsiness, social discomfort, and underlying decency with a remarkable earnestness, pairing his perfect tousled locks with snug cardigans over silly graphic tees. There is a perpetual agitation to his physicality, particularly in the early stretches where he struggles with basic motor function, that gradually gives way to a more assured presence. In

Project Hail Mary

Director: Phil Lord and Christopher Miller

Cast: Ryan Gosling, Sandra Hüller, James Ortiz, Lionel Boyce

Storyline: A science teacher wakes up on a spaceship with no recollection of who he is or how he got there, and soon discovers he must solve the riddle behind a mysterious substance that's causing the sun to die out

the process, Gosling seems to have simultaneously evolved into the best iteration of the internet's long-running "He's Literally Me" fixation, as Grace embodies a version of that archetype that feels healthier, more outward-looking and far more generous than its edgier predecessors.

Grace soon reaches his destination solar system having slowly remembered that he was not chosen for this mission so much as cornered into it as a last-minute replacement on a one-way trip to figure out why this lone star system has somehow dodged the astrophage apocalypse that's busy dimming the Sun and freezing Earth. The loneliness of that setup is immediately punctured when he spots another spacecraft already in orbit, and what follows is a surprisingly courteous bit of orbital flirting before finally committing to a handshake. That handshake is a 3D-printed alien tunnel bridging the gap, capped off by a transparent xenonite wall that lets them stare each other down. It is through that pane that Grace first meets Rocky, a five-limbed, rock-built creature of interlocking mineral plates, forged in a high-pressure ammonnia world and navigating entirely through a *chiaroscuro* echolocation.

The first contact is nervy before it finds rhythm, with both of them mirroring movements awkwardly and avoiding any serious eye contact. From there, the film doubles down on the mechanics of understanding, and this is where it gets properly fun: Rocky starts 3D-printing little physical models to explain concepts, essentially turning language into Lego, while Grace builds a translation system by mapping sound to meaning– both approaches clunky at first and then gradually syncing through a lot of trial and error. It is one of the film's smartest stretches because it renders the act of communication as actual, physical work instead of sheer movie magic.

The film quickly shifts into a collaborative mode that ties directly into the central mission, with new bunk-buddies Grace and Rocky working together on an interstellar boys trip to investigate why Tau Ceti has resisted the astrophage infection that is consuming

stars across multiple systems. Their partnership develops within this framework of shared labour and improvised fixes. But what makes their bromance so effective is the way both characters approach problems with a similar literal-minded troubleshooting, stripping communication down to instruction, response and verification, which produces a kind of tender neurodivergent intimacy.

Formally, this is Greig Fraser doing what he does best, which is making scale feel tactile instead of abstracted, and making the most of the IMAX format, so the void of space feels genuinely vast while the human body inside it always looks slightly outmatched. Big visual ideas land cleanly, from the eerie sweep of the Petrova Line to the strange, almost organic behaviour of astrophage and the shimmering, hostile beauty of Tau Ceti and its planets.

The runtime does start to show its hand in the final stretch, which keeps circling the landing strip, and the script never quite pushes beyond the comforts of a well-made studio blockbuster, though there is an honesty to that choice which works in its favour because the film is clearly more interested in the process of figuring things out than dressing itself up as something profound.

Project Hail Mary is a rare piece of large-scale science fiction that chooses optimism without irony. In a moment where most end-of-the-world stories feel like they're reflecting the worst instincts of the present, this one sneaks in softer, more persistent ideas, that may be enough to tilt things the other way. Perhaps the image of Ryan Gosling in his slightly scuffed-up, nerdy little glasses, flashing that dogged, dumbass smile while walking along an alien shoreline with his autistic alien bestie, many light years away from home, feels like a perfectly decent reason to keep going. I too would abandon humanity to spend my days teaching a bunch of sentient rocks, because if it wasn't obvious already... he is indeed literally me.

Project Hail Mary is currently running in theatres.